

# Error Spotting

## COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

---

### What You'll Learn

Error spotting presents a sentence split into three or four underlined/lettered segments (A, B, C) plus a 'No error' option (D), and asks which single segment contains a grammatical mistake — unlike full sentence correction, you never rewrite anything, so the skill is fast, segment-by-segment scanning for one of a small set of recurring error types. Because the sentence is pre-split, the error is always fully contained within one segment's boundary, which means you can often localize it to one segment before even naming the exact grammar rule violated. This sub-module covers the segment-scanning method, article errors, preposition errors, countable/uncountable number errors, hidden redundancy within a single segment, the 'No error' trap, and the short list of error types that account for most questions in this exact format.

### 1. The Segment-Scanning Method

Read each lettered segment as a near-independent unit and ask 'is there anything grammatically wrong contained entirely within this segment' — because the sentence is split at natural boundaries, most errors are self-contained within one segment rather than spanning two.

- 'A few (A) / of the students was (B) / absent from the class today (C) / No error (D).'

Scanning segment by segment: A is fine, B contains 'was' where the plural subject 'students' requires 'were' — the error is isolated entirely within segment B.

### 2. Article Errors (a/an/the)

Look for a missing article before a singular countable noun, a wrongly used 'a' before a vowel sound (should be 'an'), or an unnecessary 'the' before a general plural or uncountable noun.

- 'He is (A) / an honest (B) / person and everyone respects him (C) / No error (D).' Here 'an' correctly precedes 'honest' because the H is silent (vowel sound) — no error, so the answer is D. Contrast with a flawed version: 'He is a honest person' — this WOULD be an error, since 'a' before a vowel sound is wrong.

### 3. Preposition Errors

Certain verbs and adjectives take one specific, fixed preposition by convention — a segment swapping in a plausible-sounding but wrong preposition is a very common error type in this format.

- 'She is married (A) / with a doctor (B) / who works at the city hospital (C) / No error (D).'

The fixed idiom is 'married TO', not 'married with' — the error is in segment B.

## 4. Countable/Uncountable Number Errors

'Fewer' is used with countable nouns and 'less' with uncountable nouns (and correspondingly 'many' vs 'much', 'number of' vs 'amount of') — mixing these up within one segment is a frequently tested, easily spotted error once you know to check for it.

- 'Less number of people (A) / attended the meeting (B) / than we had expected (C) / No error (D).'

'Number of people' is countable, so it requires 'Fewer', not 'Less' — the error is in segment A.

## 5. Redundant Words Hidden in One Segment

A segment can be grammatically valid on its own but contain a redundant word or phrase that repeats meaning already present elsewhere in the sentence — these are subtler than outright grammar breaks and require checking the segment against the sentence as a whole, not just in isolation.

- 'He returned back (A) / to his hometown (B) / after ten long years (C) / No error (D).'

'Returned back' is redundant ('return' already implies 'back') — the error is in segment A, even though 'returned back' is not ungrammatical on its own.

## 6. The 'No Error' Trap

A meaningful fraction of questions genuinely have no error, and test-takers under time pressure often talk themselves into 'finding' a flaw in a perfectly correct sentence — if no segment violates a nameable rule after a careful pass, trust 'No error' rather than second-guessing based on style preference alone.

- 'The team worked (A) / tirelessly through the night (B) / to meet the deadline (C) / No error (D).'

Every segment is grammatically sound and idiomatic — the correct answer is D, 'No error', even though a test-taker might feel tempted to flag something out of habit.

## 7. The Short List of Recurring Error Types

In practice, the overwhelming majority of error-spotting questions test one of: subject-verb agreement, article usage, fixed prepositions, countable/uncountable mismatches, tense consistency, or redundancy — running through this exact checklist per segment is faster than reading for a vague 'sounds wrong' feeling.

- A quick mental checklist while scanning each segment: 'Does the verb agree with its subject? Is the article correct? Is the preposition the conventional one? Countable vs uncountable? Consistent tense? Any redundant repetition?' — running this list top to bottom on the segment most likely to be flawed resolves most questions in seconds.

## Common Pitfalls

---

- Reading the whole sentence for a general 'feel' instead of scanning each lettered segment against a specific checklist of error types.
- Missing a countable/uncountable mismatch ('less number' instead of 'fewer number') because it doesn't sound obviously wrong out loud.
- Overlooking a redundant phrase ('returned back', 'repeat again') because the segment is grammatically valid in isolation.
- Second-guessing a genuinely correct sentence into 'No error' questions and inventing a flaw that isn't really there.
- Confusing a fixed-preposition error with a merely stylistic preference, and skipping past a real error because it 'sounds okay'.
- Assuming the error must span two segments and overlooking that placement-test error-spotting errors are always self-contained within one segment.

## Key Takeaways

---

- Scan each lettered segment against a fixed checklist: subject-verb agreement, articles, prepositions, countable/uncountable, tense, redundancy.
- An error-spotting mistake is always self-contained within one segment — you don't need to look across segment boundaries.
- 'Fewer' pairs with countable nouns, 'less' with uncountable — check this pairing explicitly in every quantity-related segment.
- Redundant phrases ('returned back') can be grammatically valid yet still be the flagged error — check meaning, not just grammar.
- Trust 'No error' when no segment violates a nameable rule; don't manufacture a flaw out of habit.
- Fixed prepositions ('married to', not 'married with') must be recalled as memorized pairs, not derived from logic.

## Learn More

### IndiaBix — Verbal Ability: Spotting Errors

<https://www.indiabix.com/verbal-ability/spotting-errors/>

### Purdue OWL — Grammar Resources

[https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general\\_writing/grammar/index.html](https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/grammar/index.html)